My passion for teaching and my classroom approach have both grown naturally from my own non-traditional path through higher education. My journey included a year at Virginia Commonwealth University, two years working in kitchens, and classes at community college before finding my way to La Salle University, a small and diverse liberal arts school in Philadelphia with dedicated faculty. Their mentorship helped set me on the path to graduate school, and I remain close to them to this day. In my work as an instructor and as a TA, I strive to pay this forward by showing my students the same trust, attention, and encouragement that I was so lucky to receive.

As an educator, I strive to make economics accessible to students from all backgrounds and levels of academic preparation. Economics, especially the more technical subjects like econometrics, can seem obscure and disconnected from students' lives. I attempt to demystify the content, in part by connecting it to their own experiences and the broader questions that interest them. I aim to show my students that economics can be useful and meaningful to everyone, regardless of their career goals, and that everyone is capable of mastering it. To accomplish this, I make myself as available as possible both in and outside of the classroom. I get to know my students as individuals, and let them get to know me, so that they will be comfortable coming to me for help.

My teaching journey began as a TA for Elements of Microeconomics, where I benefited from a great team of TAs and an experienced instructor in Associate Teaching Professor Muhammad Husain. They taught me to go beyond our formal responsibilities to help our students; we organized supplementary review sessions before midterms and prepared extra practice materials. I learned that students were reluctant to travel to the economics department and began holding office hours in the library cafe. It is not enough to make yourself theoretically available to your students; you need to position yourself so they will actually take advantage of it. I developed a willingness to learn from those more experienced than me, and it has been an honor to play that role for others by organizing and leading the undergraduate economics TA training sessions.

Much of my philosophy was developed during four semesters as TA for undergraduate econometrics. Econometrics has a reputation as a difficult class, and many students enter with trepidation. I start the semester by gauging students' levels of excitement, nervousness, and preparation. I emphasize that a simple hypothesis test contains much of the intuition they will need: the statistic and its sampling distribution get more complicated, but if students understand a basic test on the mean of a Normal distribution, they will be able to grasp much of the content. As the material grows more complicated I take pains to make connections with the basic concepts. I employ concrete examples from economics and everyday life in every section. I find that these connections help students approach new material in manageable steps and that examples give life to abstract concepts.

While not all students will take advantage of my open-door policy, I have seen the impact that it can have when they do. Perhaps my most rewarding experience as a TA occurred in my second semester of econometrics. Hanna struggled on the first midterm, but expressed a commitment to staying in the class and putting in the work to pass. Because she had a conflict with my office hour, we set up special sessions on Friday afternoons where we could review the week's material and work through questions together. Not only was her final exam more than sufficient to pass the class, Hanna had improved by several letter grades, perhaps the biggest leap I have ever seen a student make. Seeing the grit and determination of students like Hanna pay off is the most gratifying experience I can

have as a teacher.

I was thrilled to be selected in the Spring 2026 semester to teach my own course on the economics of higher education. This was a small, general audience class of 11 students and so required careful design to make it understandable and accessible to all. Because the class was discussion-based, I worked especially hard to foster an open and safe environment where students felt comfortable speaking up. I was touched by the trust they showed: several students would share about their experiences as first generation students, and others how the perspectives of their immigrant families had shaped their goals.

I collected a few forms of student feedback throughout this course. At the start of each class, students would participate in a closed-note writing exercise. This helped me make sure students were engaging with and understanding the material and identify where I should speed up and slow down. I also gave students the opportunity, both in class and by email, to give feedback on the progression of the material and where they were interested in going. At several points I reevaluated and shifted my original plan to create a more sensible learning sequence.

One of my goals was to introduce students to how economists analyze decision making – in other words, how to "think like an economist." I structured the class around constructing a conceptual model of the education system. We devoted sessions to the choices of students, universities, and policymakers, and then asked how we could fit them together. We discussed how an economist might move from this conceptual model to a formal mathematical description, how they might be able to test the model with data, and why economists like this approach. Finally, we explored how to use the model to answer various questions, such as the impacts of student loan forgiveness.

I am eager to continue teaching, in particular to design my own econometrics course and to develop my course on higher education into an upper-level class. I am also prepared to teach labor economics (for which I am currently TA) and introductory and intermediate microeconomics. While I particularly enjoy leading small discussion-based classes, I have found my biggest impact as an educator is in making technical material intuitive and accessible, and so I particularly look forward to teaching courses in empirical methods.

I am grateful that my work as a TA has been recognized. I have received a rating above the 90^{th} percentile in five of the six semesters I have been a TA, and was awarded the Joel Dean Undergraduate Teaching award, given by the economics department for excellence as an instructor or TA, in the three years I was eligible. My solo course received a rating of 4.67, comparing favorably to the schoolwide mean (median) of 4.24 (4.0). More gratifying than numerical ratings are the times that students reach out after a course is over and express their appreciation.

The nature of my academic work means that teaching and research are intertwined in a special way. My research agenda in education has been inspired by many of the same experiences which have driven me as an educator. As part of my dissertation I mentored several community college students in their own independent research. These amazing students directly inspired my own work, and I hope to continue mentoring and advising students going forward. For me, teaching and research are inherently connected, and I struggle to imagine pursuing one without the other.